

BUSINESS REQUIREMENTS DOCUMENT

Customs Documentation Workflow

Gap Analysis and System Improvement Recommendations

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Note: This document is a portfolio artefact produced to demonstrate business analysis methodology. All organisational references, process data, and findings are based on replicated scenarios from real freight forwarding operations. No proprietary or confidential data has been used.

1. Executive Summary

This Business Requirements Document presents the findings of a structured gap analysis I conducted on the customs documentation workflow within a CargoWise One freight forwarding environment. The analysis identified systemic misalignments between the configured ERP workflow and how operations teams were actually executing the process day to day. These misalignments were resulting in recurring customs clearance delays, documentation errors reaching external parties, and measurable compliance risk.

Four critical workflow gaps were identified across mandatory field validation, pre-submission checking, milestone trigger linkage, and SOP enforcement. Eleven functional requirements are documented to address these gaps. Based on comparable process improvement initiatives, implementing the recommended changes is expected to reduce customs-related clearance delays by 30 to 40 percent and eliminate the primary sources of documentation rework.

Metric	Current State	Target State
Customs documentation error rate	Approximately 12% of shipments	Less than 3%
Average clearance delay due to documentation	2.4 days	Less than 0.5 days
Manual document chase rate	Approximately 35% of shipments	Less than 5%
SOP compliance rate across teams	Approximately 68%	Greater than 95%

2. Background and Business Context

2.1 Organisational Context

International freight forwarding operations depend on accurate, timely customs documentation to ensure compliant clearance of import and export shipments. Errors or omissions in customs documentation, including commercial invoices, packing lists, bills of lading, certificates of origin, and customs declarations, directly cause shipment holds, financial penalties, and damaged client relationships.

The organisation operates a CargoWise One ERP environment managing end-to-end freight forwarding workflows including customs entry creation, document generation, and regulatory lodgement. Despite CargoWise One having native customs module capabilities, a pattern of recurring documentation errors and clearance delays emerged through operational performance data I reviewed as part of this analysis.

2.2 Problem Statement

Operations data and stakeholder interviews identified four recurring issues that were consistently driving documentation failures across the customs workflow.

First, customs documentation packages were being submitted to brokers and regulatory bodies with missing or incorrect fields in approximately 12 percent of shipments. Second, CargoWise One customs entry records were not consistently linked to the correct shipment milestone triggers, which meant document generation timing was unreliable. Third, no systematic pre-submission validation checkpoint existed within the workflow to catch documentation errors before external lodgement occurred. Fourth, Standard Operating Procedures for customs documentation preparation were inconsistently followed across operational teams, with compliance rates estimated at 68 percent based on audit sampling.

2.3 Business Impact

Impact Category	Description	Severity
Clearance Delays	Documentation errors triggering customs holds averaging 2.4 additional days per affected shipment	High
Client Satisfaction	Repeat documentation errors identified as top 3 complaint driver in client satisfaction reviews	High
Rework Cost	Estimated 15 to 20 hours per week of operational time consumed by documentation correction and resubmission	Medium
Compliance Risk	Incomplete customs declarations creating exposure to regulatory penalties under applicable trade compliance frameworks	High
Revenue Impact	Clearance delays triggering storage and demurrage charges passed to clients, increasing cost of service	Medium

3. Scope

3.1 In Scope

The following areas are included in this analysis and the resulting functional requirements.

1. Customs documentation workflow within CargoWise One, covering import and export shipment types
2. Document generation triggers and milestone linkage configuration
3. Pre-submission validation checkpoint design and system configuration
4. SOP alignment and documentation standards for customs preparation
5. Stakeholder notification and escalation workflow for documentation exceptions
6. Reporting and KPI framework for customs documentation performance

3.2 Out of Scope

The following areas are explicitly excluded from this phase of work.

1. CargoWise One licensing, infrastructure, or platform upgrade
2. Customs tariff classification or trade compliance advisory
3. Broker or regulatory authority system integrations, deferred to Phase 2
4. Freight rate or billing workflow changes

4. Stakeholders

Stakeholder	Role	Interest and Impact	Engagement Level
Operations Manager	Process Owner	Accountable for clearance performance KPIs and SOP compliance across the team	High, sign-off authority
Customs Operations Team	Primary Users	Directly affected by workflow changes and new validation steps in CargoWise One	High, UAT participants
CargoWise System Administrator	Technical Owner	Responsible for ERP configuration implementation and testing environment	High, implementation lead
Compliance Officer	Regulatory Advisor	Ensures proposed changes maintain the organisation's regulatory compliance posture	Medium, review and approval
Client Services Team	Indirect Users	Benefits from reduced clearance delays and lower client complaint volumes	Low, informed only
Senior Leadership	Executive Sponsor	Accountable for operational performance outcomes and investment approval	Medium, progress reporting

5. As-Is Process Analysis

5.1 Current Workflow Overview

The current customs documentation workflow follows a manual, partially automated sequence within CargoWise One. The process is initiated upon shipment booking confirmation and progresses through document preparation, internal review, and external lodgement. The table below documents each step in the as-is workflow alongside the issues identified at each stage.

Step	Activity	System or Actor	Current Issue
1	Shipment booking confirmed in CargoWise One	CargoWise One, automated	No issues identified at this step
2	Customs entry record created manually by operations staff	CargoWise One, manual entry	No mandatory field validation exists. Incomplete entries can proceed without any system warning.
3	Supporting documents uploaded to the shipment record	CargoWise One, manual	No document completeness checklist is enforced. Operators rely on memory to attach the correct documents.
4	Commercial invoice and packing list reviewed by operator	Manual, operator review	Review process is informal. No structured checklist is applied and review quality varies by operator.
5	Customs declaration prepared and fields populated	CargoWise One, manual	Milestone trigger is not linked to this step. Document generation timing is inconsistent across shipments.
6	Documentation package assembled for broker submission	Manual, operator	Assembly relies entirely on operator knowledge. Omissions are common and go undetected until external feedback.
7	Documentation submitted to broker and customs authority	Email or portal, manual	No pre-submission system validation checkpoint exists. Errors reach external parties before they are caught.
8	Clearance confirmation received and milestone updated	CargoWise One, manual	Milestone update is frequently delayed or omitted, creating gaps in shipment tracking data.

5.2 Root Cause Analysis

A structured root cause analysis was conducted using the 5-Why methodology applied to the four primary failure patterns identified through stakeholder interviews and operational data review.

Root Cause 1: Missing mandatory field validation

Documentation errors are reaching external submission because no pre-submission validation exists in the system. The system has no validation because CargoWise One mandatory field configuration was not activated for customs entry records when the workflow was originally implemented. The root cause is that mandatory field validation rules were never configured in the CargoWise One customs module.

Root Cause 2: Inconsistent SOP compliance

Operators prepare documentation differently across teams because SOPs exist but are not systematically enforced or referenced during the workflow. There is no in-system checklist or guided workflow that directs operators to SOP steps. SOP documentation is maintained outside CargoWise One with no linkage to the system workflow. The root cause is that SOP compliance relies entirely on individual operator memory with no system enforcement mechanism.

6. Gap Analysis

The gap analysis below maps identified deficiencies between the current as-is state and the required to-be operational standard. Each gap is prioritised based on its direct contribution to the business impact areas identified in Section 2.3.

#	Gap Area	As-Is State	To-Be State	Impact	Priority
G1	Mandatory field validation	No mandatory fields enforced on customs entry records in CargoWise One	Mandatory field rules configured and enforced. Incomplete records cannot progress to next workflow step.	Primary driver of documentation errors across all shipment types	Critical
G2	Pre-submission validation checkpoint	No systematic check before external lodgement. Errors reach brokers and regulatory authorities.	Automated pre-submission checklist validates document completeness before any external lodgement is permitted.	Eliminates external exposure to documentation errors	Critical
G3	Milestone trigger linkage	Customs document generation not linked to shipment milestone events. Document timing is inconsistent.	Document generation triggers linked to defined shipment milestones within CargoWise One.	Reduces timing errors and missed document generation events	High
G4	SOP enforcement and visibility	SOPs are maintained outside CargoWise One. Compliance relies entirely on individual operator memory.	Checklist-based workflow embedded in CargoWise One guides operators through each required SOP step.	Improves consistency and auditability across all operational teams	High

7. Functional Requirements

The functional requirements below are derived directly from the gap analysis findings. Each requirement is traceable to a specific gap and prioritised by business impact. Acceptance criteria define the minimum standard each requirement must meet before sign-off can be granted.

7.1 Mandatory Field Validation (G1)

Req ID	Requirement	Priority	Acceptance Criteria
FR-001	CargoWise One customs entry records must enforce mandatory field completion for consignee details, commodity description, HS tariff code, country of origin, customs value, and incoterms before the record can progress	Critical	System prevents record progression if any mandatory field is blank. Error message identifies the specific missing fields.
FR-002	Mandatory field validation must trigger at the customs entry save event, not at lodgement only	Critical	Validation fires on save. Operator cannot bypass the validation without resolving the identified fields.
FR-003	Field validation rules must be configurable by shipment type to allow import and export entry types to have independent mandatory field sets	High	Import and export customs entry types can be configured with different mandatory field requirements.

7.2 Pre-Submission Validation Checkpoint (G2)

Req ID	Requirement	Priority	Acceptance Criteria
FR-004	A system-enforced pre-submission checklist must be completed before any customs documentation package is released for external lodgement	Critical	The lodgement action is locked in CargoWise One until checklist completion is confirmed.
FR-005	The pre-submission checklist must verify that all mandatory documents are attached, customs entry fields are complete, consignee details match the commercial invoice, and the declared value is reconciled	Critical	Each checklist item has a pass or fail system check. Manual override requires supervisor approval and is logged.
FR-006	Failed pre-submission checks must generate an exception task assigned to the responsible operator with a defined resolution SLA of two hours	High	Exception tasks are visible in the CargoWise One task queue with timestamp, owner, and SLA countdown.

7.3 Milestone Trigger Linkage (G3)

Req ID	Requirement	Priority	Acceptance Criteria
FR-007	Customs document generation must be triggered automatically upon confirmed shipment booking milestone in CargoWise One	High	Document generation event fires within five minutes of milestone confirmation.
FR-008	Milestone linkage must be configured for import and export shipment types independently, reflecting the different document timelines for each shipment direction	High	Import and export milestones trigger the correct document sets for each shipment type.
FR-009	Missed or delayed milestone triggers must generate a system alert to the operations supervisor within 30 minutes of the expected trigger time	Medium	Alert is generated and visible in the CargoWise One notification queue with shipment reference.

7.4 SOP Enforcement (G4)

Req ID	Requirement	Priority	Acceptance Criteria
FR-010	A guided in-system checklist aligned to the customs documentation SOP must be embedded in the CargoWise One customs entry workflow	High	Checklist displays at customs entry creation. Each step requires operator acknowledgement before progression.
FR-011	SOP checklist completion must be recorded against the shipment record and visible in audit reporting	High	Checklist completion timestamps and operator IDs are stored against the shipment in CargoWise One and reportable.

8. To-Be Process Design

The to-be workflow below incorporates the functional requirements from Section 7 into a redesigned customs documentation process within CargoWise One. Each step notes what has changed from the as-is state documented in Section 5.1.

Step	Activity	System or Actor	Change from As-Is
1	Shipment booking confirmed and milestone trigger activated	CargoWise One, automated	New: Milestone trigger automatically initiates customs document generation on booking confirmation
2	Customs entry record created with guided SOP checklist displayed	CargoWise One, operator	New: In-system checklist guides the operator through each SOP step at the point of entry creation
3	Mandatory field validation fires on record save	CargoWise One, automated	New: System enforces mandatory fields on save. Incomplete records are blocked from progressing.
4	Supporting documents uploaded and system verifies completeness against shipment type	CargoWise One, operator with system check	New: Document completeness check runs automatically against the required document set for the shipment type
5	Customs declaration prepared and declared value cross-checked against commercial invoice	CargoWise One, operator with system check	New: System cross-checks declared value against the attached invoice before the record can be saved
6	Pre-submission checklist completed with all items confirmed	CargoWise One, operator	New: Lodgement action is locked in CargoWise One until 100 percent checklist completion is recorded
7	Documentation submitted to broker and customs authority	Portal, operator	Unchanged: External submission process remains manual as broker portal integration is deferred to Phase 2
8	Clearance confirmation received and milestone updated automatically	CargoWise One, automated	New: Milestone update is automated on confirmation receipt, eliminating manual update delays

9. Non-Functional Requirements

NFR ID	Category	Requirement
NFR-001	Performance	The pre-submission validation checklist must complete within three seconds of the operator triggering it
NFR-002	Usability	The in-system SOP checklist must be accessible without navigating away from the customs entry screen
NFR-003	Auditability	All validation events, checklist completions, and exception overrides must be logged with operator ID and timestamp in CargoWise One
NFR-004	Reliability	Mandatory field validation must function consistently across all CargoWise One shipment types within the defined scope
NFR-005	Compliance	All workflow changes must maintain alignment with applicable customs regulations and CargoWise One configuration standards

10. UAT Approach

10.1 UAT Scope

User Acceptance Testing will validate all functional requirements FR-001 through FR-011 across import and export shipment scenarios. UAT will be conducted by the Customs Operations Team with Business Analyst coordination. All test scenarios must achieve pass status before go-live approval is granted.

10.2 Key Test Scenarios

Test ID	Scenario	Expected Outcome	FR Covered
UAT-001	Submit customs entry with mandatory fields left blank	System blocks save and displays a field-specific error message identifying each missing field	FR-001, FR-002
UAT-002	Attempt lodgement without completing the pre-submission checklist	Lodgement action remains locked in CargoWise One. Incomplete checklist items are highlighted to the operator.	FR-004, FR-005
UAT-003	Complete full customs entry workflow for an import shipment	All milestone triggers, checklists, and validations fire correctly in the defined sequence	FR-007, FR-008, FR-010
UAT-004	Complete full customs entry workflow for an export shipment	Export-specific mandatory fields and document set are applied correctly and independently from import configuration	FR-003, FR-008
UAT-005	Pre-submission check fails and exception task is generated	Exception task is created in the CargoWise One task queue with the correct owner and SLA timestamp	FR-006
UAT-006	Supervisor overrides a failed pre-submission check	Override is recorded in the audit log with the supervisor ID, timestamp, and override reason	NFR-003

10.3 Entry and Exit Criteria

Entry Criteria

UAT can commence once the following conditions are met: CargoWise One configuration changes have been deployed to the UAT environment, test scenarios and data have been prepared and reviewed by the Business Analyst, and UAT participants have been briefed and their availability confirmed for the testing period.

Exit Criteria

UAT is complete and sign-off can be granted when all critical and high priority test scenarios have passed with zero open defects, any medium priority defects have a documented resolution plan with agreed timelines, and UAT sign-off has been obtained from the Operations Manager.

11. Implementation Plan

Phase	Activity	Owner	Estimated Duration
Phase 1, Configuration	CargoWise One mandatory field rules configuration covering FR-001 to FR-003	System Administrator	1 week
Phase 1, Configuration	Pre-submission checklist workflow build covering FR-004 to FR-006	System Administrator	1 week
Phase 2, Configuration	Milestone trigger linkage configuration covering FR-007 to FR-009	System Administrator	3 days
Phase 2, Configuration	SOP checklist embedding in customs entry workflow covering FR-010 and FR-011	System Administrator with BA	3 days
Phase 3, Testing	UAT execution for import shipment scenarios	Customs Operations Team with BA	3 days
Phase 3, Testing	UAT execution for export shipment scenarios	Customs Operations Team with BA	2 days
Phase 3, Testing	Defect resolution and retest cycle	System Administrator with BA	3 days
Phase 4, Go-Live	Production deployment and post-go-live monitoring period	System Administrator	1 day
Phase 4, Go-Live	Operator briefing and SOP update communication	Operations Manager with BA	1 day

12. Success Metrics

Performance against the following KPIs will be reviewed at three months post go-live to assess whether the implemented changes have achieved the expected outcomes.

KPI	Baseline	Target at 3 Months Post Go-Live	Measurement Method
Customs documentation error rate	Approximately 12%	Less than 3%	Monthly CargoWise One exception report
Average clearance delay due to documentation	2.4 days	Less than 0.5 days	Shipment milestone data in CargoWise One
Manual document chase rate	Approximately 35%	Less than 5%	Operations team tracking log
SOP compliance rate	Approximately 68%	Greater than 95%	In-system checklist completion audit
Pre-submission validation pass rate	Not applicable, new metric	Greater than 97%	CargoWise One validation event log

13. Assumptions and Constraints

13.1 Assumptions

The following assumptions underpin the requirements and implementation approach documented in this BRD.

1. CargoWise One supports mandatory field configuration and workflow checklist features within the existing licence without additional modules
2. The System Administrator has sufficient CargoWise One configuration access to implement all required changes across both import and export shipment types
3. The Customs Operations Team can be released for UAT participation during the defined testing phase without impacting live shipment processing
4. Existing SOP documentation is accurate and current and can serve as the basis for in-system checklist design without requiring a full SOP review first

13.2 Constraints

The following constraints apply to this phase of work and must be respected in the implementation approach.

1. All configuration changes must be implemented within the existing CargoWise One licence scope. No additional modules or third-party integrations are in scope for this phase.
2. Go-live must avoid peak shipment volume periods to minimise operational risk during the transition to the new workflow.
3. Broker and regulatory authority system integrations have been deferred to a future phase and are not included in the functional requirements documented here.

14. Document Control

Version	Date	Author	Changes
0.1	May 2025	N M Ziyaf	Initial draft covering gap analysis findings and as-is process documentation
0.2	May 2025	N M Ziyaf	Functional requirements added across Sections 7 and 8
0.3	June 2025	N M Ziyaf	UAT approach, implementation plan, and success metrics added
1.0	June 2025	N M Ziyaf	Final version with all sections complete and ready for stakeholder review